

fire with last-minute grand-slam last year.

Ex-Wacoan Walls Swings Big Bat

Bragan has been getting .352 hitting out of Lee Walls, a former Waco performer who never could make it in the big time for any other boss. Bragan said before the season started that Walls could help him and no one is asking him to back down on the prediction yet.

He also is juggling his players like another Casey Stengel and getting the right pinch-hitter in the right place at the right time and coming up with tight pitching in the clutch. And, of course, he is winning more than he's losing.

After five years of basement baseball, Bragan's revival work in Pittsburgh has to go down as one of the season's more refreshing accomplishments.

When Bragan was in Waco for a luncheon talk in February, he

listed a lack of power as one of his more pressing worries. Thomas, Long and Walls have helped ease that headache and now from the Southern Association comes word that more aspirin is on the way. It comes in the form of Emil Panko, an outfielder of rock-ribbed dimensions who has an eye for distance. In his first 27 games for Andy Cohen's Pelicans, Panko is hitting .340 and is leading the league in homers with nine and in RBI's with 27.

To this desk, Panko is a familiar name. Two seasons ago at Country Campus Pittsburgh's ranking scout Ed McKarrick was asked to pinpoint the best candidate in camp. He thought a minute, then put his finger on Panko.

Cohen, getting his first good look at the Yonkers, N. Y., native, agrees with the choice.

Panko Had 500-Foot Homer

Predicting the 21-year-old youngster is sure to go on up, Cohen said last week: "This kid has a great eye and almost perfect timing. My prediction is that by the season is over he'll have every pitcher in the league worried every time he steps up to the plate. He hit a ball in Chattanooga that must have traveled 500 feet on a line over the center field fence and he fires grounders so fast between second base and the first base foul line that he has the infielders on that side backing up on the grass.

"I'm not saying now that this boy is another Mickey Mantle, but

if Mantle is any more powerfully built than Emil, Mickey can go into the next Mr. America contest."

New hands now hold the Pittsburgh controls but Long and Thomas and Bob Friend and Panko are all Branch Rickey products. Baseball's aging genius labored without apparent fruit for five years in the Pirate vineyard. Now he's retired, and as he moves into the background his products burst into the light. It is not inconceivable that Rickey recruits may yet produce a winner for victory-starved Pittsburgh.